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For Whom, for What and How?

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Cover Page Image: *Gaza, October 2023, little boy amid the rubble © United Nations Photo*

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About the Author

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Introduction: A War Against Futures, a Crime Against Memory

What is unfolding in Gaza today is not a war in any conventional sense. It is not a case of mistaken targets or tragic collateral damage. It is a systematic, brutal, and highly visible annihilation of a people-executed not only by bombs, but through starvation, displacement, and the calculated destruction of the very conditions that allow a society to regenerate. At the heart of this violence is a deliberate targeting of the present to eliminate the future: by killing children en masse and stripping women of their ability to give birth safely, nurture life, or raise children in dignity. The attack on Gaza is not only physical-it is ontological. It is not only genocide, but epistemicide.

The concept of epistemicide, coined by Portuguese sociologist Boaventura de Sousa Santos in the early 2000s, refers to the systematic destruction of a people's knowledge systems, cultural memory, educational structures, and intergenerational transmission of identity. It was originally used to describe the erasure of indigenous and colonized knowledges by Western colonial powers. Today, Gaza exemplifies this concept in horrifying clarity. When schools are bombed, teachers killed, libraries burned, and children silenced-not just in death but in the trauma that makes memory impossible-a people's future is not only under siege, it is being erased.

This paper contends that what is occurring in Gaza today is a layered violence: a genocide aimed at physical elimination, and an epistemicide aimed at the destruction of Palestinian futures. It analyzes how women and children have become the strategic targets of war-not as a consequence, but as policy. It further situates the global response, or lack thereof, within a historical pattern of moral collapse, where silence becomes complicity, and the right to resist is criminalized while the right to bomb is protected.

Children and Women as Strategic Targets: Wiping Out Future Generations

The tragedy unfolding in Gaza is not accidental-it is methodical. Over 17,000 children have been orphaned (UNICEF). Thousands more are maimed for life (Euro-Med Monitor), their bodies scarred and limbs lost to targeted bombings and shrapnel. The womb, symbolizing continuity, has become a silent battleground. More than 50,000 pregnant women have been left without access to obstetric care (UNFPA). Many are forced to give birth in tents, amidst rubble, or on terror-stricken streets, often without medical assistance (WHO).

How do you sing lullabies in the ruins of your home?
How do you imagine a future when even the present is being erased?

This is not collateral damage. It is a militarized blueprint—children are not dying by miscalculation; they are selected as soft targets. The bombing of schools, the starvation of toddlers, the trauma of orphanhood-these are deliberate acts of policy, not unintended horrors.
Crippling children mentally and physically ensures a generation robbed of not only limbs, but also of memory, curiosity, and critical thought. With education decimated, so too is the capacity

to dream, to resist, to narrate truth. What remains are fractured bodies and silenced minds-a population rendered vulnerable, voiceless, and easier to manipulate.

What happens when children forget how to ask "why"?
When the story of their past is buried in silence?

Women-life-givers-are turned into mourners before they can become mothers. Wombs are weaponized.

What does it mean when the womb is less safe than a battlefield?

There is no space safe enough for childbirth. No arms left to cradle newborns. The ability of a society to reproduce itself-in dignity, care, and continuity-is being obliterated. These are crimes not just against lives, but against possibility itself.

This is not merely the wiping out of people. It is the calculated destruction of those who hold the future-the caregivers, the educators, the storytellers, the questioners.

And those who survive? Many are left with amputated limbs, visual and hearing loss, neurological damage, and deep psychological scars. Children with Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD) panic at the sight of planes freeze at the sound of sirens. These are not only damaged lives; they are futures systematically incapacitated.

Some now warn that Gaza is becoming a living laboratory for military-technological experimentation-on trauma, AI surveillance, predictive drone policing. The surviving bodies of children and women may be treated not as humans, but as data for testing power without conscience.

When a child is seen not as a future citizen but as data, what remains of humanity?
When women become carriers of grief instead of life, what future can rise from that soil?

With each passing hour, Gaza's capacity to think, question, teach, nurture, and remember is being extinguished. This is where Gaza becomes not only a site of genocide but of epistemicide-the murder of a people's knowledge, memory, and cultural continuity. When schools are flattened and teachers killed, the transmission of identity is severed. What is destroyed is not only the present-it is an entire civilization's future.

Who benefits from a world where no child can read history, no girl can dream, no boy can recall his grandmother's song?

With deliberate cruelty, the occupation ensures that even the survivors are shadows of what they could have been.

Will we let their stories disappear before they are even told?
Or will we become their voice, their memory, their resistance?

Starvation as a Weapon: The Politics of Food Denial

In Gaza, food has become more dangerous than bullets. According to UNICEF, 90% of Gaza's population now faces hunger. Community kitchens lack oil, flour, and basic staples. People have been bombed while queuing for bread and lentils. In one heart-wrenching case, a ten-year-old boy sent to collect food returned in pieces. "I only got his shoes back," cried the father. These are not unfortunate scenes from a chaotic warzone. These are episodes in a state-engineered program of mass starvation.

Starvation, as per Article 8 of the Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court, is a war crime when used against civilian populations. In Gaza, aid is not merely delayed; it is blocked, bombed, or instrumentalized for political control. Food trucks are selectively allowed to enter as acts of propaganda. Humanitarian workers are targeted (Al Jazeera). Meanwhile, military jets and drones face no such delays. Bombs reach faster than bread. The simplest meal becomes a death sentence. Food is no longer a right but a weapon. The latest pattern of killing is luring the desperate ones to choose between dying starved and be shot before collecting bare minimum aid in so called Aid Centres.

What language remains when bread becomes a crime?
When hunger becomes a method of control?
When mothers must choose which child to feed, knowing the other may not survive the night?

In Gaza, hunger is not an accidental consequence of conflict-it is a method of war.

Healthcare systematically Dismantled: When Healing Becomes Impossible

The destruction of Gaza's healthcare system is not collateral; it is intentional. The World Health Organization has reported that only one hospital remains partially functional in the region. Medical personnel work without anesthesia. Premature infants die in powerless incubators. Dialysis patients fade from untreated disease. Birth is not a beginning here—it's a sentence into trauma.

This is not simply a collapse. It is a strategic dismemberment of care. The act of giving life is rendered as dangerous as receiving death. There are no safe places-not for the unborn, not for the elderly, and certainly not for the wounded. Gaza has been turned into a laboratory of suffering, where human life is tested against the limits of endurance while the world watches.

What kind of world forces doctors to choose who gets to breathe one more day?

Real-Time Genocide: A Global Failure of Institutions

What makes this genocide uniquely terrifying is its visibility. Every atrocity is photographed, documented, archived, and livestreamed. The International Court of Justice has acknowledged a "plausible risk of genocide" in Israel's actions in Gaza. And yet, international institutions have failed to enforce their own mandates. Ceasefire resolutions are vetoed, humanitarian corridors blocked, and legal mechanisms paralyzed. Neutrality has become a convenient cloak for complicity.

How can silence be neutral when bombs fall every hour?

The world is not failing to act because it lacks information-it is failing to act because it lacks the moral will. The global order that rose after World War II with the promise of "Never Again" is now enabling genocide through its bureaucracy, its veto power, and its silence.

The Moral Majority Speaks: Resistance from Below

In stark contrast to institutional inaction, global civil society has erupted in protest. From New York to Kuala Lumpur, Cape Town to Paris, from university campuses to border convoys, people across more than 52 countries are marching for Gaza's survival. These are not isolated protests. They are humanity's immune response to atrocity. They are the whispers of justice in a world gone numb.

These actions, from encampments to humanitarian caravans, affirm that while governments may fail, people still rise. They affirm that silence is not the only response possible. They remind us that another future is not only imaginable-it is being claimed through resistance.

The Cruel Theatre of Rebuilding Gaza

And now, as the dust still swirls from the destruction, the same nations who funded the war speak of rebuilding Gaza.

Rebuilding for whom? The dead? The maimed?
The traumatised children who can't sleep without nightmares?

These reconstruction efforts are not about dignity. They are about contracts, optics, surveillance systems, and market interests. It's a grotesque theatre of power.

How do you rebuild a city while burning its bones?
How do you replant seeds when you've salted the soil?
Can you rebuild joy from ashes? Can concrete replace lost memory?

Conclusion: Gaza and the Soul of the World

Gaza is not merely a humanitarian crisis-it is a test of the global conscience. The genocide in Gaza demands more than aid. It demands memory, justice, and accountability. If the world continues to look away, what is at stake is not only Palestinian survival, but the very essence of our shared humanity.

Let this not be a moment remembered for silence. Let history record that when genocide knocked, some of us opened our mouths and refused to be quiet. Let it be known to the children of Gaza, whose nights echo with drones instead of lullabies that their suffering was not ignored-we heard their pain and stood with them.

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